diplomatic profiles on Twitter to the number of influential leaders, scholars, or entrepreneurs that have benefitted from Indian government scholarships in their education. The Indian government's liberal proclivity to label a variety of initiatives as examples of soft power – from yoga to the export of hydroxychloroquine – poses a further challenge to identify the right soft power objectives, tools, and results.

All countries face such challenges in their soft power strategies, but China has certainly emerged as a key player in recent years, pushing India to up its game. A 2017 parliamentary report accordingly recognises that the ICCR "is being forced to resort to juggle its limited resources to make do with the meagre budget" and recommends doubling its budgetary allocation to upgrade and extend the reach of the country's cultural diplomacy in South Asia and beyond.[76] Under the leadership of former External Affairs Minister Sushma Swaraj, cultural diplomacy was elevated as a top foreign policy priority, with effects well beyond ICCR capacity or a rise in number of scholarships. For example, in 2019, the Ministry of External Affairs' (MEA's) Development Partnership Administration created a new division that specifically supports cultural heritage conservation and renovation efforts abroad.

Fourth, Indian decision-makers should recognise that its culture of pluralism may not always be welcome in target countries. For states whose focus is on short-term developmental goals or that have less democratic regimes, India's message of religious, social, economic, and political diversity may not be appealing. In some instances, India's culture of pluralism may be perceived as incompatible or even threatening local governance models and values. India's attempt to distinguish itself from China is thus expected to face competition from Beijing's own soft power strategy, with an increasing authoritarian allure that delivers more efficiently in the short run.[77]